

May Thy will be done, until I *(we)* bring to completion

the good work which I *(we)* have desired to do, [*or*: any good work which I *(we)* will desire to do]

...

if it be pleasing to Thy will.

For it is easy for me *(us)* to will it,

but to do it is not within my *(our)* power,

unless I *(we)* receive grace from Thee;

though in truth both are Thine, "to will and to do".

Prayer, edited, from HOMILY FIFTY-EIGHT, of St Isaac of Syria

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/of-isaac-the-syrian-before-any-good-work.docx>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/of-isaac-the-syrian-before-any-good-work.pdf>

HOMILY FIFTY-EIGHT, of St Isaac of Syria

TO CHOOSE WHAT IS GOOD belongs to the good volition of the man who desires it; but to realize the choice of the good volition belongs to God. For this a man has need of God's help. Therefore we accompany our good desire with constant prayer, and we pray not only because we need help, but also so that we can distinguish whether it is pleasing to God's will or not. For not every fair-seeming desire falls into the heart from God, but only that which is profitable. It happens that a man desires good, but God does not help him therein; for a semblance of a good desire may also enter a man from the devil. It seems to the man that this is for his help, but often it is beyond his measure. The devil himself contrives this for the man's detriment and compels him to seek a thing, although he has not yet attained to this mode of life; or because it is alien to his monastic state;¹ or because when he moves the man to accomplish his desire, it is not the right time to do so;² or because the man has neither the knowledge nor the bodily strength sufficient for it; or because the present moment does not lend us a hand. The devil strives in every way under the guise of some good thing to trouble the man, or to harm his body, or to set a hidden snare in his intellect.

Howbeit, let us make constant prayer fervently, as I said, with respect to the good desire that arises within us, and let each of us say:

'May Thy will be done, until I bring to completion the good work which I have desired to do, if it be pleasing to Thy will. For it is easy for me to will it, but to do it is not within my power, unless I receive grace from Thee; though in truth both are Thine, "to will and to do." (Phil, 2:13) For it is not without Thy grace that I was persuaded to accept this desire incited within me, or was I moved by it.'

The habitual practice of the man who desires good with a discerning intellect is this: in prayer to labor for it continually, and through prayer to receive power that aids him in doing it and wisdom to distinguish what is genuine from what is counterfeit. The good is discerned by much prayer, by toil and watchfulness, incessant yearning, constant tears and humility, and by assistance from Heaven, especially when a man has proud thoughts which oppose it; for these obstruct God's help from us, though we may abolish them by prayer.

May Thy will be done, until I *(we)* bring to completion

the good work which I *(we)* have desired to do, [*or*: any good work which I *(we)* will desire to do]

...

if it be pleasing to Thy will.

For it is easy for me *(us)* to will it,

but to do it is not within my *(our)* power,

unless I *(we)* receive grace from Thee;

though in truth both are Thine, "to will and to do".

Prayer, edited, from HOMILY FIFTY-EIGHT, of St Isaac of Syria

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/of-isaac-the-syrian-before-any-good-work.docx>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/of-isaac-the-syrian-before-any-good-work.pdf>

TO CHOOSE WHAT IS GOOD belongs to the good volition of the man who desires it; but to realize the choice of the good volition belongs to God. For this a man has need of God's help. Therefore we accompany our good desire with constant prayer, and we pray not only because we need help, but also so that we can distinguish whether it is pleasing to God's will or not. For not every fair-seeming desire falls into the heart from God, but only that which is profitable. It happens that a man desires good, but God does not help him therein; for a semblance of a good desire may also enter a man from the devil. It seems to the man that this is for his help, but often it is beyond his measure. The devil himself contrives this for the man's detriment and compels him to seek a thing, although he has not yet attained to this mode of life; or because it is alien to his monastic state;¹ or because when he moves the man to accomplish his desire, it is not the right time to do so;² or because the man has neither the knowledge nor the bodily strength sufficient for it; or because the present moment does not lend us a hand. The devil strives in every way under the guise of some good thing to trouble the man, or to harm his body, or to set a hidden snare in his intellect.

Howbeit, let us make constant prayer fervently, as I said, with respect to the good desire that arises within us, and let each of us say:

'May Thy will be done, until I bring to completion the good work which I have desired to do, if it be pleasing to Thy will. For it is easy for me to will it, but to do it is not within my power, unless I receive grace from Thee; though in truth both are Thine, "to will and to do." (Phil, 2:13) For it is not without Thy grace that I was persuaded to accept this desire incited within me, or was I moved by it.'

The habitual practice of the man who desires good with a discerning intellect is this: in prayer to labor for it continually, and through prayer to receive power that aids him in doing it and wisdom to distinguish what is genuine from what is counterfeit. The good is discerned by much prayer, by toil and watchfulness, incessant yearning, constant tears and humility, and by assistance from Heaven, especially when a man has proud thoughts which oppose it; for these obstruct God's help from us, though we may abolish them by prayer.